

Part of Sadvari's job is to put a number on the gold digger's value at the end of that relationship. The younger they are, the higher the price. And it makes sense. In the older man/younger woman dynamic, her best years will be spent "off the market," so to speak.

A number of elements factor into Sadvari's equation—for instance, what she does for a living and whether marrying the man means she'll have to give that up, and her lifestyle expectations for herself and any children she may bring into the marriage. It's a fascinating idea, placing a money value on youth and fertility, but that's the cold hard truth. Lots of women walk away when they realize that, in the event of divorce, the marriage won't yield them any gains. But some persevere.

At his office, Sadvari keeps a box of Kleenex in the cabinet behind him. Tears tend to flow when people are talking about money, motives, and marriage. He told me about a young client who took one look at a prenuptial agreement, one that would leave her with next to nothing if she and her partner split. That's when the waterworks began. Drying her eyes, she asked for advice.

"I didn't want to interfere, but I made it pretty clear that the guy in the equation was overreaching," he said. "Overreaching" is a legal way of saying he built a legal fortress around his fortune, one that would be impenetrable even to a clever judge. This, Sadvari suggested, indicated that the relationship she was in might not be a great one on which to bet her youth.

"This woman, however, went ahead with the marriage, knowing full well she was getting nothing at the end." Twenty-five years later, that couple is still together, Sadvari said. It was a love match. She became a force on the philanthropy front, and he is a happy and supportive husband. The prenup was a gamble that worked out for both parties.

But for every happy ending, Sadvari has also seen how massive wealth can be eroded in just one generation by a succession of marriages that cost a small fortune in divorces. One of his clients is on his fourth marriage. He is more broke than he's ever been, but he didn't have the heart to institute fierce prenups.

"What can I say? The guy's a romantic," Sadvari laments.